in East Berlin and were eventually ‘bought out’ for a reported U$1.8 million, adding a psychological strain on already delicate ties between the two Germanys.

Despite these embarrassments, an energetic 73-year-old Erich Honecker continued to dominate the SED and Government. By the beginning of 1985, the British ambassador observed how he retained the appearance of running the country flawlessly, noting his ‘skilful and realistic management’ reduced the conflicting pressures on and within the GDR – ‘especially that of people hankering to enjoy the interests and satisfactions of the modern world’. Age, too, had made him gentler in manner, he charmed visitors and flattered colleagues where he could. His self-confidence became even more assured when the decrepit Chernenko died on 11 March and was replaced by Mikhail Gorbachev, the youngest member of the ruling Soviet Politburo. In way of congratulation, Honecker’s carefully prepared laudatory message sending ‘cordial and fraternal greetings and congratulations’ was broadcast twice that same day on GDR state television:

The CPSU Central Committee elected into this highest function of Lenin’s party a tested Marxist-Leninst and internationalist, a good friend and comrade who enjoys the respect and high esteem of the communists and all working people in the GDR. The GDR and the SED will continue to be a close ally, loyal friend and reliable companion of Lenin’s country.

With all their strength, the GDR citizens support the USSR’s consistent struggle, rich in initiative, for the ensuring of peace and the prevention of a nuclear catastrophe. Inspired by the 40th anniversary of victory over fascism and our people’s liberation by the glorious Soviet Army, the workers in our country attain great achievements for the comprehensive strengthening of the first worker-peasant state on German soil and firm member of the socialist community.